

those." But back at my desk making buy-and-sell decisions, my bias will come out.

I will also tell you this: if I'd done no such tinkering, I'd have been better off.

I don't always have a notion of where the market's headed, but usually I do. I've found that sometimes I'm right and sometimes I'm wrong. All in all, my calls are useless. If I were always wrong, that would be terrific. Somebody could make a fortune using my forecasts as a reliable contrary indicator.

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My market-timing predictions are useless.

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Several years ago, in early January, our team in the office decided, over a cheerful lunch, to guess where the Dow Jones Industrial index, then at 2190, would be at the end of the year. We all jotted down our predictions and handed them in. I came up with 2316, and by a strange coincidence, my wife also picked 2316.

"How did you get *your* number?" I asked her.

"Well," she said, "my birthday is on the twenty-third and our daughter's is on the sixteenth, so . . ."

"Ridiculous!" I declared. "Mindless superstition!"

"Okay," said Leah, "so how did *you* pick 2316, Mr. Economic Forecaster?"

"Simple," I said. "My account number at the club is 2316."

As it happened, the Dow closed the year at 2342, so we hadn't done badly. Our methodologies were probably as reliable as most of the highly sophisticated predictive systems.

All of us would like to be able to sell all our stocks the day before a market crash. But how do you do it? Bombarded with, and confused by, divergent views in the media, many probably end up de-